

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared as a blog post:

Gap Year: Work or Travel?

Students always face many tests and exams. Taking a break from studies for a year and having a rest sounds attractive. A “Gap year”, usually taken after the end of secondary school and before starting university, provides an opportunity for students to explore the world, look for a richer spiritual life and exchange cultural ideas.

What did Hong Kong students do during their gap years? Oscar Chan Chi-kin, a year one business student at the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, didn’t go to university immediately. Instead, he went to Singapore in his gap year and volunteered to help young people develop leadership skills. “Instead of being career-driven, I hoped to gain a life direction and figure out what I love to do,” he said. After the gap year, he knew what his ideal working environment would look like in his future career. “Whether the company vision aligns with my personal values is really important.”

Besides travelling and volunteering, young people from Asia also choose to intern and work to enrich their resumés and sharpen their competitive edge. However, Sascha Choi On, a student who has just started studying at CUHK has a different view: “Nowadays it’s changing. Some of my friends took a gap year because they really wanted to find a sense of self, such as ‘who I am’ and ‘what the goal in my life is’. Some students really care about their inner peace and happiness rather than just focusing on earning money,” she said.

You are invited to participate in a round table discussion at the Hong Kong Youth Forum about taking a gap year after secondary school. You may want to talk about:

- benefits of taking a gap year
- challenges of taking a gap year
- activities young people could do during their gap year
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you like to take a gap year?
2. What would you do during a gap year?
3. Would you prefer to volunteer or to travel during a gap year?
4. Where would you like to travel to during a gap year?
5. Do you know what career you would like to pursue?
6. Do you think taking a gap year is popular among Hong Kong young people?
7. How can students make sure that their gap year is not wasted?
8. How would travelling during a gap year help somebody’s career?